

Child Protection Policy

LIFE INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL

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Forward

Life International School (LIS) believes that our most sacred responsibility as a Christian organization is to dedicate ourselves to the safety and welfare of our students. When they are safe and happy, they will be able to learn and thrive. In Matthew 18: 5-6 Jesus said "And anyone who welcomes a little child like this on my behalf is welcoming me. But if anyone causes one of these little ones who trusts in me to lose faith, it would be better for that person to be thrown into the sea with a large millstone tied around the neck."

This policy seeks to guide and ensure that everyone involved in the LIS community has been educated on the matter of the health, safety, and wellbeing of all children in attendance at our school. Our policy is based on the international law and on the United Nations (UN) Convention on the Rights of the Child as states below:

Article 19 - Protection from abuse and neglect:

The State shall protect the child from all forms of maltreatment by parents or others responsible for the care of the child and establish appropriate social programs for the prevention of abuse and the treatment of victims.

Article 34: Sexual Exploitation:

The State shall protect children from sexual exploitation and abuse, including prostitution and involvement in pornography

Along with these statements, LIS is required to follow local Cambodian Law. The most recent update demands that LIS shall appoint a Child Protection Committee within its staff to implement actions plans and report to the Cambodian Ministry of Education Youth & Sport.

Life International School is also concerned for the welfare of its staff, faculty, administrators and volunteers. This policy is intended to provide a structure that enables employees and volunteers to guard their personal integrity against any accusation. It is also intended to provide clear and specific expectations and standards that are expected of them in their respective roles.

All staff, faculty, administrators, and volunteers are required to carefully read, prayerfully consider, and fully agree to the procedures and commitments detailed in this policy.

Introduction

Life International School is committed to providing a safe learning environment for all children to thrive and grow spiritually, morally, socially, physically, and mentally. LIS is dedicated to cultivating a culture of dignity, love, and respect towards others and is compliant with Cambodian laws and regulations to ensure child safety.

LIS has developed age-appropriate child safety education for its students at all grade levels, increasing their confidence and ability to react to dangerous situations. Using these research-based programs, LIS staff prepare students to develop skills and attitudes to keep themselves safe.

Schools hold a sacred responsibility to protect the children that come under its care and give them the opportunity to learn in a safe, loving environment. It is the responsibility of educators to identify and report any situations in which they suspect child harassment or abuse. Reporting and follow up of all suspected incidences of child abuse or neglect will proceed in accordance with administrative regulations respective to this policy.

This policy gives clear instruction and guidance on how any member of the school community can report concerns or observations related to student safety and protection. School policy and procedures are followed in the event of any cases of misconduct, minor behavioral issues, as well as any suspicions and reports of harassment and/or abuse.

Mark 10:13-16

13 And they were bringing children to him that he might touch them, and the disciples rebuked them. 14 But when Jesus saw it, he was indignant and said to them,

"Let the children come to me; do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of God. 15 Truly, I say to you, whoever does not receive the kingdom of God like a child shall not enter it."

16 And he took them in his arms and blessed them, laying his hands on them.

Definitions of Abuse

1. 'Children and teenagers' is defined as any child and young adults up to 20 years of age who are enrolled at LIS.
2. 'Child Abuse' constitutes 'all forms of physical and/or emotional ill-treatment, sexual abuse, neglect or negligent treatment or commercial or other exploitation, resulting in actual or potential harm to the child's health, survival, development or dignity in the context of a relationship of responsibility, trust or power.' [World Health Organization].
3. UNICEF (United Nation's International Children's Emergency Fund) provides the following definitions concerning abuse:
    a. **Physical Abuse:** Physical abuse will be defined as "… that which results in actual or potential physical harm from an interaction or lack of an interaction, which is reasonably within the control of a parent or person in a position of responsibility, power or trust. There may be a single or repeated incidents" (Krug et al., 2002).
    b. **Sexual Abuse:** Child sexual abuse is "the involvement of a child in sexual activity that he or she does not fully comprehend, is unable to give informed consent to, or for which the child is not developmentally prepared and cannot give consent, or that violate the laws or social taboos of society. Child sexual abuse is evidenced by this activity between a child and an adult or another child who by age or development is in a relationship of responsibility, trust or power, the activity being intended to gratify or satisfy the needs of the other person." Report of the consultation on child abuse prevention, 29-31 March 1999. Geneva, World Health Organization, 1999 (document WHO/HSC/PVI/99.1).
    c. **Emotional Abuse**: Emotional abuse involves "the failure to provide a developmentally appropriate, supportive environment, including the availability of a primary attachment figure, so that the child can develop a stable and full range of emotional and social competencies commensurate with her or his personal potentials and in the context of the society in which the child dwells. There may also be acts towards the child that cause or have a high probability of causing harm to the child's health or physical, mental, spiritual, moral or social development. These acts must be reasonably within the control of the parent or person in a relationship of responsibility, trust or power. Acts include restriction of movement, patterns of belittling, denigrating, scapegoating, threatening, scaring, discriminating, ridiculing or other non-physical forms of hostile or rejecting treatment" (Krug et al., 2002).
    d. **Exploitation:** Commercial or other exploitation of a child refers to "use of the child in work or other activities for the benefit of others. This includes, but is not limited to, child labor and child prostitution. These activities are to the detriment of the child's physical or mental health, education, or spiritual, moral or social-emotional development" (Krug et al., 2002). Child exploitation also includes the recruitment and use of children in armed conflict, child trafficking and the sale of children.

e. **Neglect:** Neglect can be defined as "the failure to provide for the development of the child in all spheres: health, education, emotional development, nutrition, shelter, and safe living conditions, in the context of resources reasonably available to the family or caretakers and causes or has a high probability of causing harm to the child's health or physical, mental, spiritual, moral or social development. This includes the failure to properly supervise and protect children from harm as much as is feasible" (Krug et al., 2002).

4. **Peer violence:** Peer violence among children. The UN Secretary-General's Study on Violence Against Children (2006) highlighted not only violence against children in the home but also in school and community settings. This may include any of the above definitions, but it occurs child to child.
5. **Inappropriate Behavior:** Inappropriate behavior encompasses unwanted attention or actions that cause physical or emotional harm. Although inappropriate actions may be non-intentional, they will be judged according to the perception of the other person.

(Asian Hope Child Protection Policy)

Child Protection Committee

In accordance with Cambodian law, LIS has established its Child Protection Committee detailed below. All positions are listed and described as directed by the Department of Education.

Components:

1. Chairperson: Associate Director
2. Deputy: Principals
3. ECE Team Leader: Members
4. Elementary Leadership Team: Members
5. Secondary Leadership Team: Members

Duties Required by Cambodian Ministry of Education Youth & Sport:

1. Prepare and Implement action plans
2. Raise awareness on child protection in the learning and teaching process.
3. Ensure student safety be cooperating with education professionals, communities, and relevant stakeholders.
4. Check, follow, and evaluate prevention procedures in order to find areas of weaknesses and strength.
5. Report regularly on the result of the Child Protection Committee to the Department of Education.

Additional Duties Required by LIS:

6. Clearly and confidentially document all efforts made by LIS in handling the incident.
7. Securely store all reports and document and keep confidential
8. Refer child and alleged abuser to professional counseling services.
9. Recommend and support disciplinary action against the respondent if circumstances require it.
10. Inform the child's parents

11. Inform the Executive Director
12. Interview respondent and discuss allegations.
13. Investigate and record allegations taking care not to taint any evidence of a student or the respondent.
14. Decide whether the allegations should be reported to authorities. If so, report immediately.
15. Contact the individual's embassy if the matter involves foreign employees.

Recruitment and Screening Process

1. All **staff** must fulfill the following requirements:
    a. Submit a criminal record from their home country plus any country they have worked in, when possible.
    b. Complete the Employee Application where they must also submit contact information for references who will be sought out by the school for confidential comments on the employee's abilities and character. The references will also be asked to give any reason as to why this person should not be allowed to work with children.
    c. All staff are required to have an interview (in person or by telephone/internet) with administration and are asked to clarify their reasons for applying to our school.
    d. All staff must adhere to the guidelines set forth in this policy, the Teacher's Handbook, and all other handbooks and/or policies provided by LIS.
2. All **volunteers** must fulfill the following requirements:
    a. Submit a criminal record from their home country plus any country they have worked in, when possible. *
    b. If the volunteer is traveling with a team, the team leader should be interviewed by administration to clarify reasons for being involved with the school as well as for the administration to share the ideals and goals of the school.
    c. All volunteers must adhere to the guidelines set forth in this policy as well as the Teacher's Handbook provided by LIS.

**For short term missionaries or mission teams, background checks for everyone might not be required if their organization has a prior relationship with the school. However, while they are serving inside the school they are not permitted to be alone with a student unless there is an LIS staff member present.*

*This fulfills duties 1 and 3 required by the Cambodian Ministry of Education Youth & Sport.

Reporting

Reporting Student Behavior

Anyone in the school community may observe or hear about an occurrence or behavior that causes concern. Reports of student misbehavior should be directed to the staff member responsible for the student at the time of the behavior. Reports of serious or repeated misconduct should be taken to a school administrator (principal or director). General concerns related to child safety and personal protection as well as reports, indicators or disclosures of suspected harassment or abuse should be submitted to the Child Protection Committee.

LIS seeks to ensure that all incidents or reports of abuse are handled promptly and professionally. All allegations will be taken seriously, and appropriate care will be given to the alleged victim(s). Appropriate answers and information should be given in a clear and direct way, free from ambiguity or evasiveness.

The following guidelines are provided for anyone seeking to report incidents of known or suspected abuse as defined by the terms listed on pages 3-4.

1. **Students:** If a student at LIS is aware of, or reasonably suspects, that any form of abuse or harm has been caused by anyone (including another child) to a student at LIS they must report it to any LIS staff.
2. **Staff:** If a staff, faculty or volunteer at LIS is aware of, or reasonably suspects, that any form of abuse or harm has been caused by anyone (including another child) to a student at LIS they must write a report (detailed in Appendix A) and give it to any member of the Child Protection Committee.
3. **Child Protection Committee:** If any member of the Child Protection Committee at LIS is aware of, or reasonably suspects, that any form of abuse or harm has been caused by anyone (including another child) to a student at LIS they must submit a written report to the Principal of the school who will then share that report with the Director.
   **If the subject of the complaint involves a member of the Child Safety Committee then the report shall be made directly to the Director.*

*This fulfills duties 1,2,3, and 4 required by the Cambodian Ministry of Education.

Disclosures

Understanding Disclosures

Adults working with children must recognize that it is often very difficult for children to disclose abuse. Understanding their fears may help the response. Students often cannot easily talk about an abuse problem because they may:

- Try to "forget" in order to cope
- Worry they will lose the love of their parents, family, or friends
- Fear the shame of abuse
- Fear they will get in trouble for telling
- Fear they will be blamed, or
- Be under threat by the offender to harm them or those close to them.

HELPFUL THINGS TO SAY

"THANK YOU FOR TELLING ME…"

"I BELIEVE YOU…"

"IT'S NOT YOUR FAULT…"

"YOU DID THE RIGHT THING TO TELL ME…"

"I WILL HELP YOU…"

Responding to Disclosures

Even though every student is an individual and each situation is unique, the following general guidelines should be followed when a student alludes to or reports an alleged incident of harassment or abuse:

- Show acceptance of what the child says, however unlikely it may sound
- Listen without interrupting
- Stay calm and look at the child directly while being sensitive to cultural differences. Do not show emotions, such as disgust or alarm
- Be honest and tell the child that you will need to let someone else know (never promise confidentiality).
- Reassure the child that even if they have broken a rule, they are not to blame for the abuse.
- Be aware that the child may have been bribed or threatened not to tell.
- Never push for information, instead let the child know that you are always ready to listen if they want to tell you more.

THINGS NOT TO SAY:

"WHY HAVEN'T YOU TOLD ANYONE ABOUT THIS BEFORE?"

"I CAN'T BELIEVE THIS/ARE YOU SURE THIS IS TRUE?"

"I AM SHOCKED"

"WHO/WHY/WHEN/WHERE/HOW?

Action Steps Following a Disclosure

Be careful to follow these steps upon receiving a disclosure of harassment or abuse:

- Let the child know what you are going to do next.
- Offer to accompany the child to see the school counselor, if needed.
- Make notes during the meeting or as soon as possible after the meeting, writing down exactly what was said (verbatim) and what was happening immediately beforehand.

- Report the disclosure to the Child Protection Committee as soon as possible (within 48 hours) using the report form provided in Appendix A.
- Consider your own feelings and seek support if needed while maintaining confidentiality for the child's sake.

(Dalat International School Child Protection Handbook)

*This fulfills duty 3 required by the Cambodian Ministry of Education Youth & Sport.

Creating a Safe Environment

Administration, faculty, staff, and volunteers of Life International School are expected to reflect the highest standards of care in their behavior towards and relationships with all children and students. They must not under any circumstances engage in physical or emotional abuse or engage in sexual contact of any nature with any student. It is irrelevant whether the conduct is consensual or nonconsensual, or condoned by parents or caregivers. The age of the student is also irrelevant. Failure to behave in an appropriate manner may result in criminal proceedings and/or disciplinary action, including dismissal. Staff who have knowledge of violation or suspected violation but neglect to report them may be subject to disciplinary action.

The Faculty, Staff or Volunteer will

1. Treat all children and teenagers with respect and dignity befitting their age, and be aware of their language, tone of voice, attitude, actions, and body language.
2. Establish and maintain an ethos where children are able to communicate, feel secure and listened to.
3. Not engage in any of the following:
    - Invading the privacy of the children when they are using the bathroom (except in cases in preschool, kindergarten, or children with special needs. In these situations, another adult must be nearby and the door to the bathroom facility must be left ajar)
    - Rough, or sexually provocative games
    - Making sexually suggestive comments about or to a young person, even in "fun"
    - Inappropriate or intrusive touching of any form
    - Any scapegoating, ridiculing, or rejecting a child or young person.
4. Not control and discipline children using physical punishment
5. Make sure another adult is present if, for example, a young child has soiled him/herself and needs to be thoroughly washed.
6. Always ensure that behavior is above reproach and not allow youngsters to engage in attention seeking that is overtly sexual or physical in nature.

7. Not demand affection by any means (e.g. demanding a kiss or hug).
8. Not invite a young person to your home alone. Invite a group or ensure that someone else is in the house. Make sure that the parent or guardian has given permission.
9. Not give rides or lifts to lone children or teenagers, other than for short journeys. If they are alone, ask them to sit in the back seat. Under no circumstances should the faculty, staff member or volunteer offer a ride on a motorcycle, moped or motorized bicycle. Parent or guardian permission is required for transporting children.
10. Not counsel or mentor outside of the guidelines of the specific program the faculty, staff or volunteer falls under.
11. Not post any photos or videos taken during school on private social media pages that include the faces of LIS students without prior permission from the principal and signed consent from the parent.

(Asian Hope Child Protection Policy)

Appendix A

Child Protection Report Form

Submit to any member of the Child Protection Committee upon completion of this form.

Your Name:

Date and time of report:

Name of person giving the report:

Name, gender, and age of child suspected to be subject of abuse or harm:

Details of the circumstances for the reporter becoming aware, or reasonably suspecting, that the child has been abused or harmed – sexually, emotionally, or physically:

Details of the actual or suspected abuse/harm:

Details of the identity of the alleged perpetrator of the abuse/harm (if known):

Details of the identity of any other person who may be able to give information about the abuse/harm (if known):

Appendix B

LIFE INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL CHILD PROTECTION STATEMENT

I declare that I have read the Life International School Child Protection Policy and agree to fully abide with all the Child Protection measures that are set in place in my field of ministry.

I also will ensure to follow the personal procedures laid out in the Employee Handbook that will act as safeguards to my personal contact with any children.

I will ensure to be alert, not to place myself in vulnerable situations with children, which will leave me open to accusation. I will do my best to always do my ministry work in the presence and observation of other adults.

I will ensure to play my part in Life International School's commitment to the welfare of all children and teenagers in Cambodia.

PRINT
NAME:_____DATE:_____

SIGN:_____DATE:_____